STEPS TO ACCOUNTABILITY: CURBSIDE RECYCLING

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TIME TO MOVE FROM STUDYING TO DECIDING

GET PRICES • CONFIRM FUNDING • MANAGE RISKS

IF REASONABLE, MOVE FORWARD

IF NOT, EXPLAIN WHY



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Steps to Accountability: Curbside Recycling

Time to move from studying to deciding.

A resident recently asked me: Why does the SCRD collect garbage and food waste at the curbside, but not recycling?

It's a reasonable question, and one the SCRD has been examining for years.

What have residents told us?

In 2021, over 70% of survey respondents supported curbside recycling, including 75.33% in Roberts Creek.

The 2026 consultation asked a different question, asking residents to rank recycling improvements rather than indicate support for curbside collection. Responses were mixed, but they don't establish that support has declined.

There is substantial public interest in this service.

Why has it been delayed?

The SCRD has legitimate concerns about collection costs, Recycle BC funding, contamination penalties and impacts on existing depots.

And our depots perform remarkably well. The SCRD already has one of BC's highest per-capita collection rates for residential packaging and paper recyclables.

Its Solid Waste Management Plan estimates curbside recycling would divert only 94 additional tonnes annually, approximately 1% of landfilled waste. That's unlikely to meaningfully extend the landfill's projected 30-year life following expansion.

But convenience, accessibility and residents' time have value too. Environmental diversion isn't the only measure of a useful public service.

What would it cost?

In 2026, Sechelt charges $303 annually for garbage, recycling and organics, compared with the SCRD's $226.63 for garbage and food waste.

That's a difference of $76.37, although the services and contracts aren't directly equivalent.

The SCRD's 2021 estimates placed curbside recycling at approximately:

- $70 annually without Recycle BC funding.
- $30–$34 annually with Recycle BC funding.

The $70 estimate would be approximately $80–85 today, adjusted for inflation.

Recycle BC funding could substantially reduce the household cost. We need current collection prices and confirmation of available funding before knowing what residents would actually pay.

What should the next Board do?

The SCRD's new Solid Waste Management Plan proposes another $100,000 for a cost review and public survey.

After years of research and consultation, do we really need to commit to another survey before knowing what the service would cost?

I would propose a straightforward process:

1. **Get the prices:** Obtain current collection costs and confirm available Recycle BC funding.
2. **Manage the risks:** Develop a practical plan addressing contamination, contracts and financial exposure.
3. **Compare expectations:** Determine whether the net household cost is consistent with residents' inflation-adjusted expectations.
4. **Decide:** If costs and risks are reasonable, proceed toward implementation.

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5. **Engage where needed:** If costs or service arrangements differ significantly from expectations, let the Board determine what additional public consultation is necessary.

Residents should be kept informed throughout.

The goal

Our existing recycling system works well, and we shouldn't exaggerate the environmental benefits of curbside collection.

But residents have expressed substantial interest in a convenient, accessible service. That deserves serious consideration.

If we can deliver curbside recycling at a reasonable cost, with available funding and manageable risks, let's move forward.

If we can't, explain why.

The next Board needs to ensure the research leads to a decision, not another indefinite cycle of studies.

That's accountability: listen, establish the facts, manage the risks, engage when necessary and make a decision.

Sources

- SCRD 2021 Curbside Recycling Survey
- SCRD 2026 Solid Waste Management Plan
- SCRD 2026 Collection Rates
- District of Sechelt Solid Waste Services